

Ground hog day

Hello, my name is James. I am a student at the University of South Utah, and I'm writing this as a way to tell you my story. So let's start at the beginning.

It was a day like any other. I woke up, got ready, went to class, grabbed lunch, and headed to my next lecture. For context, I had scheduled my first class for the late morning (10:00–11:30), and my second class in the late afternoon (15:00–16:30).

On this particular day—May 19, 2009—everything seemed normal. But throughout the day, I kept noticing the same person watching me. At first, I thought I was just being paranoid. I mean, why would anyone be watching me? But as I'll explain later, I couldn't have been more wrong. Or rather, I couldn't even begin to comprehend what was actually happening.

Weeks passed, and yet I kept seeing the same person everywhere I went. So I did what I believe most people would have done: I walked up to him and asked if he was following me. The moment I said that, he looked me in the eyes and, in a flat, emotionless voice, said,
“I hate you. You will soon be punished.”

Then he ran away.

The next day went by as usual. But it was the day after that made me want to write this story—though I had to survive the nightmare first.

On the morning of May 30, 2009—two days after he ran from me—I woke up feeling... off. Something wasn't right. I brushed it off and went about my day as usual. At school, everything was normal until I left my last class. I turned a corner—and that's when it happened.

I felt a sharp sting in my back, then the warmth of blood trickling down. I collapsed. As I turned around, I saw him standing over me, knife in hand, a small smile creeping onto his face. As everything faded to black—

—I woke up in my bed, drenched in sweat. My clock read May 30.

"Just a bad dream," I told myself.

But the feeling didn't go away.

I continued my day. But again, after my last class, I turned the same corner—and it happened again. The same sting, the same fall, the same man, the same grin.

This cycle continued. Sixty times? Eighty? I lost count. No matter what I did—change routes, hide, even try skipping class—it always ended the same. Me, stabbed. Him, grinning.

“Today is the day,” I told myself, finally convinced I had found a way to break the loop.
“Just survive until midnight.”

I tried to follow what I'd seen in a movie, but that ended badly. So what was my genius plan?
Simple: hide in the park all day. Then, just before midnight, sprint to the police station and report what he had done—or was going to do.

As soon as I woke up, I put on my shoes and ran straight to the park, hiding in the wooded area.
“I don't see him,” I whispered to myself.

Night fell. Still no sign of him.
When my watch hit 11:45 PM, I sprinted out of the park and down the road. Only the sound of my shoes hitting the pavement and the occasional distant voice accompanied me.

Just as I thought I was safe...
There he was. Standing in the middle of the road.
Knife in hand.

It was five minutes to midnight. I was far enough away that I could run if he chased me.

“Why are you doing this?” I asked.

His response still sends chills down my spine:

“I. Hate. You.”

Cold. Distant. Hollow.

As the clock neared midnight, he raised the knife and drove it into his own skull—killing himself instantly. That same grin remained frozen on his face.

And again... I woke up in my bed.

Now I knew what I had to do. I had no choice.

I put on my shoes and left.

As soon as I saw him, I did what I believed had to be done. Without a second thought, I plunged a knife into his back.

He gasped, turned around. His face wore an expression I can only describe as stunned disbelief. The color drained from his cheeks as he collapsed. I stood over him until I was certain he was dead.

Later that day, the police arrived and arrested me for murder. I didn't resist. I accepted this as the outcome.

At the police station, after being questioned, they determined I was unfit to rejoin society. The judge at my trial agreed:

“Mr. Jake, you will be placed in maximum security under 24-hour surveillance, with no possibility of parole.”

Now, as I sit in my cell, I write this to stay sane. I have books. I have paper. But I know that won't be enough for long.

The clock reads June 18, 2017.

It read that yesterday, too.

And again today.

I feel it happening again. This time, I'm ready to escape—for good.

But who could be behind it now?

I look around my room. Nothing. Out the small cell window into the hallway—still nothing.

Then, I check the one place I never dared to look before.

Slowly, I walk to the window that overlooks the courtyard. Inmates are laughing, playing, talking...

And there he is.

Standing alone in the corner.

Grinning.

I'm the only one who sees him.

Alden Esterhuizen

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